

"Female infanticide is a mental illness. We cannot call ourselves citizens of the 21st century by practising such a crime...we kill our daughters in the womb...this is our mental poverty"

— PM MODI, *at the launch of Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao scheme in 2015*

A WELCOME CASCADE

» The pre-natal testing ban became a precursor to subsequent campaigns centred around the girl child—Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao, for instance

» According to NFHS-5 (2019-21), the overall sex ratio in India has improved and the country is moving closer to the global sex ratio

» The female literacy rate in India has also improved, and stood at almost 70 per cent in 2022


cover story FEMALE FOETICIDE

Missing GIRL Child

16 STATES and Union Territories with 70 districts have recorded an abnormal decline in the child sex ratio (CSR) between 1991 and 2001.

23 CITIES.

FROM THE ARCHIVES
Nov. 10, 2003

Cover Story
Missing Girl Child

"How can I help you?" asks the female gynaecologist. I tell her I am in my mid-30s, hypertensive, have a 14-year-old son but am pregnant again. "Will you do a sex-determination test for me and an abortion if I don't want to continue the pregnancy?" I ask tentatively. "Do you know it is illegal?" she asks. And then adds, "But I will call a radiologist who will do it after you complete 12 weeks of pregnancy"

– Shefalee Vasudev

ments unless registered with the Act, and restricted the use of such techniques to cases of suspected genetic abnormalities. Offences under the Act were cognisable, non-bailable and non-compoundable, with imprisonment of up to three years and/or a fine.

India legalised abortion in 1971 and pre-natal testing techniques arrived soon after. It became the perfect answer in a society fixated on the male child and treated daughters as a liability. The test was conducted using a procedure called amniocentesis, where a needle was inserted to tap the amniotic fluid to determine the child's sex, followed by abortion. The test did not come cheap but if it bought you social acceptance, surely the extra bucks couldn't hurt. By the 1980s, cost too ceased to be a deterrent with the coming of ultrasound technology where the sex of your child was revealed in plain sight on an ultrasonograph. That knowledge proved fatal for it enhanced the 'missing girl' phenomenon, as the SRB galloped to 110 boys per 100 girls in the 1990s, where it stayed stuck for the next 20 years. In 2003, the PNDT Act was amended to bring pre-conception under its ambit, and was accordingly renamed PCPNDT or Preconception and Prenatal Diagnostic Techniques (Prohibition of Sex Selection) Act.

9 MILLION

girls gone "missing" between 2000 and 2019 due to female-selective abortions, as per a Pew Research Center analysis

The act in itself was never going to be enough to stop female foeticide. The SRB in India peaked at 111 in 2011, necessitating awareness and advertising campaigns around prioritising the girl child. The Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao campaign, launched in 2015, was intended to fulfil that role. It may not have wreaked a miracle, but it has moved the needle a fraction. India's SRB is beginning to come down again, though it is still some distance away from normal. ■